which grows and matures with each passing year, sometimes even discarding old policies that are no longer relevant.

Integrated Battle Groups

One thought that had been buzzing in my mind right from my Brigade Commander days, was our long Observe-Orient-Decide-Act (OODA) loop. In any organization, the shorter the decision-making loop the better, which can only be achieved through a flatter hierarchical organization. At the operational level, we have the Battalion HQ, Brigade HQ, Division HQ, Corps HQ and Command HQ. Far too many in my opinion. Could we not restructure ourselves to become more operationally efficient, by removing one layer in this chain of the decision-making process, through the merger of the Brigade and Divisional HQ? I had floated this idea during one of the Corps War Games, but it did not find any takers.

It is not that the current organization was wrong. It had merit at the time it was conceived when means of communication, both physical (road, rail, air) and electronic (radio, line, data) were poor. Therefore, it required HQ at regular intervals to process information, aggregate it and send it up the chain for decision-making at the Corps or Command level, before following the same chain in its downward path to convey the orders/decisions taken to those who had to execute them. With the advancements that had taken place, particularly in the electronic domain, it was now possible to expand the span of control at every level. This thought was further reinforced when I was the Chief of Staff in 33 Corps, which looked after the defence of Sikkim. Between Nathu La and Gangtok, a distance of only 30 km or so as the crow flies, were four HQs. Could this not be reduced by merging the Brigade and Division into one entity?

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